Coda

Launching an indigenous shipping line continued to be a dream for some in Tuticorin despite the disaster of SSNCo. In December 1946, M.C. Veerabahu (1903–76), a local Congress-man, lawyer, businessman and a member of the Constituent Assembly established the Swadeshi Steamship Company in Tuticorin. The name evokes VOC's shipping dream. Soon the company acquired a steamer and named it *Chidambaram*. On 2 February 1949, the steamer was formally launched by C. Rajagopalachari, then the governor general of India. We may recall that Rajaji, as a young lawyer in Salem, had taken shares in SSNCo and had also probably hosted VOC on his tour to raise share capital. Apart from contributing to the Tirunelveli 'Riots' defence fund he had also sponsored, in 1916, the publication of the second edition of VOC's *Agame Puram*.[1] In launching the steamer, he heaped fulsome praise on VOC. 'I can imagine him looking at us with tears of joy, not unmixed with generous amusement'. The event was not without ironies. Rajaji's host was none other than the Harvey Bros; and BI had withdrawn its service to give way to the *Chidambaram*.

> The wrong done to Tuticorin [said Rajaji] has been righted, and I have great pleasure in inaugurating this service and I have the honour of giving the name of our dead valiant hero V.O. Chidambaram Pillai to this ship that will carry our flag.[2]

Unfortunately, the new swadeshi company too collapsed, and VOC's name was linked to another failed enterprise. When A.P.C. Veerabahu, M.C. Veerabahu's nephew founded the V.O. Chidambaram College in Tuticorin in 1951, many urged him not to name it after VOC. However, he persisted. The college has flourished and is now nearing its diamond jubilee.

In 1961, *Kappalottiya Tamilan* ('the Tamil Helmsman'), a biopic was made starring Sivaji Ganesan in the lead role. Directed by B.R. Panthulu,